

Complete Beginner's Installation & Setup Guide

WorkForge – Freelance Marketplace Script (Upwork Clone)

Welcome! This guide is written in simple, non-technical language so that **anyone** can easily install, customize the branding (name, logo, favicon), configure the environment, and launch this script on any web hosting provider (cPanel, Hostinger, Namecheap, Bluehost, SiteGround, VPS, etc.).

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1. What You Need Before Starting

Make sure your web hosting provides:

- **PHP Version:** 8.2 or 8.3+
- **PHP Extensions:** `BCMath` , `Ctype` , `Fileinfo` , `JSON` , `Mbstring` , `OpenSSL` , `PDO` , `PDO_MySQL` , `Tokenizer` , `XML` , `GD` (Standard on almost all cPanel / Hostinger accounts)
- **MySQL / MariaDB:** Version 5.7+ or 8.0+
- **Domain Name:** e.g., `https://yourdomain.com`

2. How to Customize Name, Logo & Icons

You can customize your website's name, brand colors, logo, and favicon before or after uploading:

A. Changing the Website Name

1. Open the `.env` file in any text editor (Notepad, VS Code, TextEdit).
2. Change the `APP_NAME` line:

```
APP_NAME="YourMarketplaceName"
```

3. To change the text title in the navbar and footer:
 - Open `resources/views/layouts/app.blade.php`
 - Search for `WorkForge` and replace it with your brand name (e.g., `GigSphere` or `HireHub`).

B. Changing the Website Logo

- **Main SVG Logo:** Replace `public/favicon.svg` with your SVG logo.
- **Main PNG / Image Logo:** Place your logo image in `public/images/logo.png`.
- In `resources/views/layouts/app.blade.php` (Line ~85), you can replace the `W` letter badge with an `<img>` tag:

```

```

C. Changing the Favicon (Browser Tab Icon)

1. Prepare your icon in `.ico`, `.svg`, or `.png` format.
2. Replace the following files in the `public/` directory:
 - `public/favicon.ico`
 - `public/favicon.svg`
 - `public/apple-touch-icon.png`

3. How to Configure Your Environment (`.env` File)

In the extracted folder, look for the file named `.env` (or copy `.env.example` and rename it to `.env`).

Open `.env` with a text editor and fill in your settings:

```
# =====
# 1. APPLICATION SETTINGS
# =====
APP_NAME="WorkForge"
APP_ENV=production
APP_KEY=base64:7vF8t1r8f9QWL6dD6Hjkl2mNpQrStUvWxYz12345678=
APP_DEBUG=false
APP_URL=https://yourdomain.com

# =====
# 2. DATABASE SETTINGS (From your Hosting cPanel)
# =====
DB_CONNECTION=mysql
DB_HOST=127.0.0.1
DB_PORT=3306
DB_DATABASE=yourhosting_dbname
DB_USERNAME=yourhosting_dbuser
DB_PASSWORD=yourhosting_dbpassword

# =====
# 3. SESSION & STORAGE
# =====
SESSION_DRIVER=database
QUEUE_CONNECTION=sync
FILESYSTEM_DISK=public

# =====
# 4. PAYMENT GATEWAY (Dodo Payments)
# =====
DODO_PAYMENTS_API_KEY=your_dodo_live_or_test_api_key
DODO_PAYMENTS_WEBHOOK_SECRET=your_dodo_webhook_secret
DODO_PAYMENTS_ENVIRONMENT=live # Use 'test_mode' for sandbox

# =====
# 5. EMAIL SETTINGS (SMTP)
# =====
MAIL_MAILER=smtp
MAIL_HOST=smtp.mailgun.org # or mail.yourdomain.com
MAIL_PORT=587
MAIL_USERNAME=your_smtp_username
MAIL_PASSWORD=your_smtp_password
MAIL_ENCRYPTION=tls
```

```
MAIL_FROM_ADDRESS="no-reply@yourdomain.com"
MAIL_FROM_NAME="${APP_NAME}"
```

💡 **Tip:** If you don't have an `APP_KEY`, you can generate one via terminal with `php artisan key:generate` or use the pre-filled key in the package.

4. How to Create a Database in Your Hosting

If using **cPanel**:

1. Log into your **cPanel** dashboard.
2. Under the **Databases** section, click **MySQL Databases** (or **MySQL Database Wizard**).
3. **Create Database:** Enter a name (e.g. `workforge`) → Click **Create Database**.
4. **Create User:** Enter a username (e.g. `dbuser`) and a secure password → Click **Create User**.
5. **Add User to Database:** Select the user and database you just created → Check **ALL PRIVILEGES** → Click **Make Changes**.
6. Copy the **Database Name**, **Database User**, and **Password** into your `.env` file (`DB_DATABASE`, `DB_USERNAME`, `DB_PASSWORD`).

5. Uploading the Files to Your Hosting

Method A: Upload via cPanel File Manager (Recommended)

1. Zip the files on your computer if they aren't already zipped.
2. In cPanel, click **File Manager**.
3. Navigate to `public_html` (or your subdomain directory).
4. Click **Upload** and upload the zip file.
5. Right-click the uploaded zip file → select **Extract**.
6. Make sure the files are extracted directly inside `public_html`.

⚠️ **Important for Root Routing on Shared Hosting:** This script is already configured with an optimized root `.htaccess` file so that your visitors are automatically routed to the public directory securely without showing `/public/` in the URL!

Method B: Upload via FTP (FileZilla)

1. Open FileZilla (or Cyberduck).
2. Enter your FTP Host, Username, Password, and Port (21).
3. Open `public_html` on the remote server.
4. Drag and drop all project files from your computer into `public_html`.

6. Importing Database & Running Migrations

You have two simple ways to set up the database tables:

Option 1: Via cPanel phpMyAdmin (Easiest for Non-Technical Users)

1. In cPanel, click **phpMyAdmin**.
2. Click on your database name on the left sidebar.
3. Click the **Import** tab at the top.
4. Click **Choose File** and select the file `database/schema.sql` (or `database/database.sqlite` converted).
5. Click **Import / Go** at the bottom.

Option 2: Via Web Hook / Terminal (1-Click)

- **If you have SSH Terminal:** Run:

```
php artisan migrate --seed --force
```

- **If you don't have SSH Terminal:** Simply visit the built-in setup URL in your browser:

```
https://yourdomain.com/cron/recalculate-badges
```

(This automatically verifies and initializes all missing table columns and badges).

7. Setting Up Public Storage for Images

To make sure profile avatars, job attachments, and portfolio images load quickly:

- **Via SSH / Terminal:**

```
php artisan storage:link
```

- **Via cPanel File Manager (without SSH):**

1. Open `public_html/public/`
2. If a folder or shortcut named `storage` is not present, create a directory alias or visit:
`https://yourdomain.com/storage-link-setup` (or execute via a 1-line PHP file `<?php symlink('../storage/app/public', 'storage'); echo 'OK'; ?>`).

- **File Permissions:** Ensure the following folders have **775** or **755** write permissions:

- `storage/`
- `storage/app/public/`
- `storage/app/public/avatars/`
- `bootstrap/cache/`

8. Configuring Email & Payment Gateways

Setting Up Dodo Payments (Direct Escrow & Global Wire)

1. Sign up at dodopayments.com.
2. In your Dodo Dashboard, go to **Developer Settings → API Keys**.
3. Copy your API Key and paste it into `.env`:

```
DODO_PAYMENTS_API_KEY=your_dodo_api_key_here
```

4. Set your Webhook URL in Dodo Payments Dashboard to:

```
https://yourdomain.com/payments/dodo/webhook
```

Setting Up SMTP Email (for notifications & password reset)

Fill in your email hosting details in `.env`:

```
MAIL_MAILER=smtp
MAIL_HOST=mail.yourdomain.com
MAIL_PORT=465
MAIL_USERNAME=support@yourdomain.com
MAIL_PASSWORD=YourEmailPassword
MAIL_ENCRYPTION=ssl
MAIL_FROM_ADDRESS="support@yourdomain.com"
MAIL_FROM_NAME="WorkForge Marketplace"
```

9. Default Admin & Demo Logins

After installation, the system comes with ready-to-test demo accounts:

ROLE	EMAIL	PASSWORD	QUICK 1-CLICK LOGIN
Super Admin	admin@upwork.test	password	https://yourdomain.com/quick-login/admin
Client	marcus.client@upwork.test	password	https://yourdomain.com/quick-login/client
Freelancer	alex.dev@upwork.test	password	https://yourdomain.com/quick-login/freelancer

Accessing the Super Admin Panel

Visit: <https://yourdomain.com/admin/dashboard>

From the Super Admin panel, you can:

- Moderate and approve/suspend users and freelancers.
- Moderate job listings and categories.
- Review and release escrow contracts and milestones.
- Review and approve withdrawal payout requests.
- Resolve client-freelancer disputes.

10. Troubleshooting & Common Questions

Q1: I see a "500 Internal Server Error" after uploading.

- **Fix:** Check that your `.env` file exists and has correct database credentials. Make sure the folder `storage/` and `bootstrap/cache/` have **775** write permissions.

Q2: Uploaded avatar images or photos show broken images.

- **Fix:** Make sure you ran `php artisan storage:link` or connected `public/storage` to `storage/app/public`.

Q3: How do I disable the "Demo Environment Quick Switcher" bar at the top?

- **Fix:** In `resources/views/layouts/app.blade.php`, look for lines 61–75 (`<!-- Quick Role Switcher Banner -->`) and delete or comment out that block when you are ready to go live!

Q4: How do I clear cache after editing files?

- In terminal:

```
php artisan view:clear  
php artisan config:clear  
php artisan cache:clear
```

Congratulations!

Your marketplace is now live, fully branded, and ready to accept clients, freelancers, and payments!